

beat them into giving up their ideas. I make no value judgement about the ideas themselves here, and of course there are some terrible ideas out there that need to be argued against, but those are usually no-brainers, and the opposition are usually a small fringe group. It's when the two sides of a debate have millions or billions of people on both sides... that's when things get a little crazy, and more and more polarised.

So how do the showdowns occur? A large group from one side comes across a smaller group (or an individual) from the other side (you, for example), and they relentlessly attack the smaller group or individual, until they either flee or give in an accept defeat. Some attacks have no desire to assimilate, merely to destroy, but every now and then you get attacks from groups or people who are looking to "convert" you to their opinion. These involve tactics like persuasion and politeness, and use (often cherry picked) facts to try and assimilate you into their groupthink.



When the borg take you over, you don't feel emotions

True, the Borg would attack and defeat, capture and then assimilate forcefully, so they seem different, but then again, perhaps the early days of the borg were just as warped as our present level of discourse.

THE HIVEMIND

Another thing the Borg were noted for was having a totally decentralised

command and control. In fact, they are a hive mind – there is no real “leader” or central processing unit that one could destroy and leave the Borg confused or in disarray, the way you could destroy all the generals of a human armed force, and leave the army confused and directionless.

The more individuals that joined the hive mind, the more powerful it would become. Of course the Borg storyline in *Star Trek* was a little convoluted at times, with a Borg queen showing up. It was first suggested that the Borg queen was just a manifestation of the hive mind, and that any individual Drone with a decent brain capacity could have been chosen to be either a Borg king or queen. This is also depicted in *The Matrix Revolutions*, where Neo goes into Machine City and meets Deus Ex Machina (god of the machines) which manifests as a large face made up of flying droids. It's also the same hive mind that makes up Eywa (basically, mother nature) in *Avatar*, which (spoiler alert) comes alive to save the day at the end by commanding all living things connected to it to attack the humans.

As for us, we might be a part of a hive mind, and not even know it. Just as everything in *Avatar* was an individual, but collectively sought to fight off the human invaders, we might very well be group-thinking, without even knowing it. Problem is, you're only capable of seeing that once you're outside a group, looking in. The most common debate is the Android vs iPhone/iOS debate, and it's easy to spot the blind spots and confirmation biases that both side's supporters display, but only if you're neither.

So is there a hive mind at work for, say, Android fanboys? Given that we live in a world where it's really hard to tell the true source of information – the sources can usually be traced back to large corporations. If it's not marketing, it's whistleblowing, and it need not even be true anymore, thanks to social media. If marketed correctly, groups of people can be made to believe anything. Marketing itself is an attempt to get you to believe something and emotionally associate with a product, so as to convince you to buy it.

DRONES

This is about us. Not the collective us as in “people” or “geeks” or any such group, but the you and me us, as individuals. Without meaning to sound like a conspiracy theorist, I have to point out that humans have amassed so much knowledge that it is literally impossible for any one human to have even a single percent of that knowledge in his or her head. Thus



The Borg queen was said to be the personification of the hive mind

we get the trust system of authorities within fields telling us what to believe. We have broken each field of knowledge into ever thinning vertical slivers of study, and then we have experts in those fields do scientific studies and arrive at conclusions and theories about what they're studying.

Now I'm not suggesting that is somehow bad, or that it should be done in another way, or anything of the sort, because all of here at Digit are firm believers in the scientific method being the only existing way of arriving at the truth about our universe. That said, it's important to realise the flaws in the current system as well.

The result of the vast amounts of human knowledge of the universe that is ever increasing is that every single day, with every single discovery and every single study, the individual human is made even dumber in the larger context. There are many phrases that are used to explain this. For example, “The more I learn, the more I realize how much I don't know”, is something Einstein said. Way before him, Socrates said “I know that I know nothing”. Then there are quotes such as “The more I know, the less I under-